

DISTORTIONS

New York University GSAS Department of Music Conference
October 2–3, 2026

Keynote Speaker - Mara Mills

(Associate Professor and Ph.D. Director in the Department of Media, Culture, and Communication at New York University)

Keynote Performer - TBA

The term distortion is derived from the Latin *dis*, meaning apart or away, and *torquere*, meaning to twist. It refers to the bending, warping, or deformation of an object's shape and/or form. In a sonic context, distortion is used to describe the alteration of an audio signal or wave. It is often characterized by a harsh, gritty sound. Through the amplification of what are generally considered imperfections, errors, or failures, distortion performs an array of functions: it interrogates, confuses, vulgarizes, disrupts, alienates, subverts. At the same time, scrubbing a recording of its so-called imperfections also involves a warping of sonic materials; attempting to rid an object of distortion only distorts further. Distortion can be weaponized by the powerful, just as it can function as a tool of resistance, liberation, and imagining. This conference explores distortion and its various overlapping contexts: sonic, political, metaphysical, aesthetic, literary, bodily, legal, and more.

The 2026 NYU GSAS Department of Music Graduate Student Conference Committee invites proposals for papers, lightning talks, roundtables, paper-performances, performances, installations, pre-formed panels (we will provide a panel chair), and other presentation formats (please consult our co-chairs for formats not listed before submitting). We welcome works that explore interpretations and expressions of distortions across a range of contexts. Contributions may engage with (but are certainly not limited to) topics and themes such as:

- distortion, overdrive, grain, synthesis, noise, static, interference;
- warping, bending, spirals, fractals, plasticity, deformation;
- disinformation, misinformation, fascism, propaganda, censorship, post-truth, conspiracy;
- fraud, fakes, forgery, bootlegging, piracy, artificiality, streaming manipulation;
- failure, corruption, glitch, mutation, transformation, translation, disruption;
- alternate realities, queer temporalities, liminality, non-place, time, space, simulation
- speculative fiction, sonic fiction, critical fabulation, futurities;
- para-sociality, circulation, cybernetics, artificial intelligence;
- superstition, urban legend, (media) folklore;
- techno-doping, surgery, biohacking;
- trauma, mental health, ghosts, haunting, vertigo, disorientation, neurodivergence and masking;
- alternate tunings, DIY instruments/music spaces, hacking, auditory illusions.

We welcome submissions from scholars and artists at any career stage, and we especially encourage graduate students and independent scholars to submit. We hope that financial concerns will not prevent anyone from submitting a proposal, and we will do our best to support travel on an as-needed basis.

Submit proposals to nyudistortions@gmail.com by **May 1, 2026**. Please include within the body of the email: the author's name, contact information, and institutional affiliation/location. Your proposal should be attached as a file, with any identifying information removed (we understand that audiovisual work samples may be difficult to fully anonymize). In your attachment, include:

For papers/presentations:

- Title
- Abstract (250–300 words)
- Preferred presentation formats: 20-minute talk, lightning talk, paper-performance, pre-formed panel
- 3–5 keywords
- A/V or other technical requirements

*Papers will be 20 minutes each, followed by a 10 minute Q&A. Lightning talks will be 7 minutes each, followed by a 5 minute Q&A. Panels will include 3-4 papers, moderated by a chair.

For performances/installations:

- Title
- Proposal (250–300 words), including piece length
- Performance/installation format: live performance, installation
- 3–5 keywords
- Hyperlinks for up to 3 relevant video/audio samples
- Equipment requirements
- Tentative stage plot

*Please note: We are interested in all performances, but our ability to accommodate certain technical aspects may be limited. The more equipment you can provide, the better. A list of our equipment is available [here](#). An engineer will be available.

Feel free to email co-chairs Hannah Krasikov, Christine Oppedisano, and Yuval Tessman-Bar-On at nyudistortions@gmail.com with any questions.

NYU Department of Music
March 4, 2026